future. Narasimhan also argued that any changes introduced in the workings of Indian intelligence agencies had been cosmetic, made without consideration for long-term strategy. He also tossed me a question: 'Why has the Chinese growth been exemplary?'

Fortunately, he answered the question himself. 'There is only one answer—economic espionage. Chinese intelligence has been stealing technology right from the start. They did it in automobiles, defence, space and various other sectors of manufacturing. We all know that some of the world's best spy organisations carry out commercial espionage. But though Indian agents are seeking a mandate for it, it has not been granted. If we can make commercial espionage a part of the R&AW's obligations, agents working undercover abroad could produce wonders. As of today, the scientific and economic advisors posted abroad just read and write reports on the basis of publicly-accessible literature, while the R&AW is confined to political and security espionage. Meanwhile, the Chinese Ministry of State Security mostly uses its agents to clone the best available technology. The R&AW has the experience and capability even for scientific espionage, but some of the best operatives in the trade remain underutilised,' Narasimhan said.

For many retired R&AW personnel, the half-century-long career of the spy agency was both good and bad. What they most wanted, they said, was clear priorities from the governments they served. On a daily basis, spying can be a routine job: gather information, analyse it and corroborate it. If the information has been procured from other sources, it needs to be verified again and again before the finished product is sent to the government of the day. Many veterans in the field agreed that the relationship between policymakers and the R&AW had been